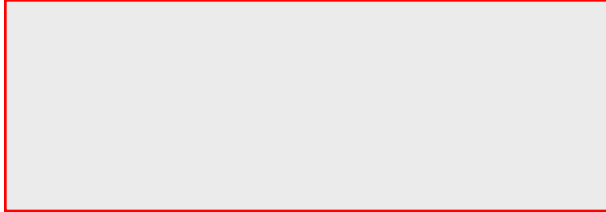
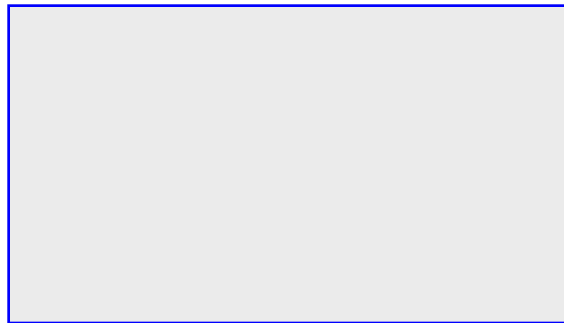


Moths at Night

Moths are the quiet relatives of butterflies and far outnumber them. Most species fly after dark and rest by day on bark or leaves. Their wings are covered in tiny overlapping scales that rub off like dust when touched. Many moths are drawn to artificial lights for reasons that are still debated.



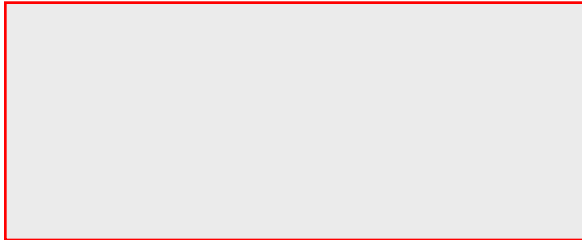
Moths have many enemies. Some moths hear the calls of hunting bats and dive away from them in mid air. This defence works because a tympanal organ on the body picks up ultrasonic clicks and triggers a sudden evasive turn that the bat cannot easily follow through the dark summer sky above the fields and hedges. Other species answer with clicks of their own that jam the sonar of their predators.



Navigation by Moonlight

Night flying insects may steer by keeping a bright light source at a fixed angle. With the distant moon this gives a straight path, but a nearby lamp turns the same rule into a spiral.

In the left column we describe field traps that use a white sheet and a mercury vapour lamp to count moths through the season.



In the right column we compare those counts with radar records of moths migrating high above the ground on warm nights.



Below the two figures the text runs across the full width of the page again and closes the section.